



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Collagen, a functional revolution in fitness

Here's why athletes across the globe are going **bonkers** over this performance protein.

It's 6:30 am.

My client — an elite athlete — walks into my clinic with aching knees after a 12 km run. He's in peak physical shape, gets eight hours of sleep, and follows a near-perfect whey-based recovery regime. Yet, the chronic joint soreness persisted. So did early signs of skin sagging at just 29. Why?

The solution, surprisingly, wasn't more protein powder — but collagen.

As a sports nutritionist with two decades under my belt, I've lived through every trend: BCAAs, glutamine, casein, vegan blends, and of course, whey protein's dominance. But in the last five years, collagen has emerged not as a fad, but as a functional revolution in athletic recovery, longevity, and injury prevention.

Let's break down the real science and reason why athletes across the globe — from runners and CrossFitters to swimmers — are choosing collagen as their primary performance protein.

What exactly is collagen?

Collagen is the most abundant protein in your body. It accounts for about 30 per cent of total protein and acts as the structural scaffolding for your skin, bones, tendons, ligaments, cartilage, and even your gut lining.

Think of it as the internal glue that keeps your body resilient and springy — the kind of resilience every athlete needs.

Unlike whey, which is a complete milk-derived protein rich in muscle-building amino acids like leucine, collagen focuses on tissue repair rather than just hypertrophy. Its amino acid profile is rich in glycine, proline, and hydroxyproline — the triple threat responsible for collagen's repair magic.

Let me be clear — whey protein still has its place. It's anabolic, quickly absorbed, and supports lean muscle mass. But here's what most sportspeople aren't told:

⚡ Whey does nothing for connective tissue. Muscle growth is just one part of performance. Your tendons, ligaments, fascia, and joints don't benefit from leucine the way they benefit from glycine and proline.

⚡ Whey can trigger digestive issues. Many of my clients with dairy sensitivities experience bloating, acne, or fatigue with regular whey use.

⚡ It's short-term focused. Whey helps you recover muscle. Collagen helps you sustain your body through years of training.

If you're serious about building not just muscle, but a body that lasts — collagen fills the gap that whey

leaves behind.

Backed by research

Still sceptical? I was too, until I delved into clinical studies:

⚡ Joint Health: A 24-week study published in the Current Medical Research and Opinion journal found that collagen supplementation reduced joint pain in athletes with activity-related discomfort.

Participants taking 10 grams of collagen daily reported significantly less pain during movement.

⚡ Tendon and Ligament Support: Collagen, when paired with Vitamin C pre-training, has been shown to improve tendon stiffness and reduce injury risk. This is game-changing for high-impact sports like football, tennis, and long-distance running.

⚡ Skin and Recovery: Collagen stimulates fibroblast activity in the skin, supporting wound healing and tissue regeneration — both essential for post-game recovery and injury management.

⚡ Bone Density: Collagen peptides can increase bone mineral density, especially crucial for female athletes prone to bone stress injuries or menstrual irregularities.

In my clinic, I've worked with many athletes. After integrating collagen into personalised recovery plans, I've observed: